

Chapter 193 - Part 1

Extra 15-1

Many years ago, someone asked Chen Mian a question: If today were the end of the world, what would you do?

After thinking, Chen Mian answered in a very soft voice: "The world can perish now."

At that time, Chen Mian was sitting on a rock at the mountaintop, the morning sun slowly rising from behind the mountain.

In the distant sky, it painted orange-pink rays of light, like fireworks blooming in the night, breathtakingly beautiful.

But Chen Mian's gaze fell on the person beside her.

The girl sitting beside Chen Mian had her hair cascading down, the morning sun's light falling on her face, gentle and beautiful.

Her lip color was somewhat pale, her figure slender.

That day she softly hummed a song.

"A lone bird flies into the Milky Way, boarding a ship

Someone raises the sail

Someone stops at the other shore"

Her voice was clear, her fair hand keeping time on her knee.

Unhurried and unrushed, steady and measured.

She said: "We might all be lone birds."

Back then, at just over ten years old, eyes could serve as cameras, capturing all the beauty within their frames.

So their eyes sparkled brightly.

She asked Chen Mian, "Why can the world perish now?"

Chen Mian remained silent.

Actually, the answer was on the tip of her tongue at that moment, but she didn't dare say it because the person beside her was too beautiful.

As if all negative words were unworthy of her who was shining at that moment.

Later, Chen Mian thought countless times—if only the world had perished at that moment.

Because she always wanted time to stop at the most beautiful moment.

That way, the world would be beautiful.

And so would you and I.

Chen Mian got up at seven in the morning.

For someone used to staying up late, getting up at this time was very difficult, but miraculously, without an alarm, she woke up before seven.

Today was the day Qi Jiao was going to the suburban morning market to stock up on flowers.

Last night after dinner, Chen Mian had casually asked about it, so she planned to drive to pick up and drop off Qi Jiao today.

When Chen Mian saw Qi Jiao, she shed tears.

Qi Jiao was at a loss and also somewhat afraid.

Later, after the two became familiar, Qi Jiao said: "I had no idea what you were trying to do."

Chen Mian didn't say she had come specifically to find her.

It was enough for her alone to remember those memories.

In fact, those memories would slowly fade as she lived her life in this world.

But that wasn't important.

What mattered was that she and Qi Jiao had reunited.

Chen Mian got up and washed her hair, applied light makeup, originally planning to wear a light-colored lipstick, but remembering that Qi Jiao said yesterday that maple leaf-colored lipstick was very pretty, she took out a maple leaf color from her makeup box and applied it.

Chen Mian, who wasn't used to wearing red tones, felt a bit uncomfortable looking at herself in the mirror.

However, she didn't have much time to deliberate, so she casually checked herself and drove out.

When she drove to the flower shop entrance, Qi Jiao was opening the door. Chen Mian walked over and said: "Let's go."

Qi Jiao looked confused: "Where to?"

"The morning market." Chen Mian said, "Aren't you going to stock up on flowers?"

Qi Jiao: "..."

Qi Jiao pointed at her own car, saying awkwardly: "I've already come back."

Chen Mian: "..."

Only then did Chen Mian learn that the morning market time was five or six o'clock.

And Qi Jiao was among the earlier batch—she'd already arrived at the morning market just after five, selecting the freshest and most beautiful flowers to bring back, then packaging them.

Chen Mian felt quite embarrassed.

But Chen Mian was someone who didn't really notice embarrassment. She just paused for two seconds before asking again: "Do you want to go eat breakfast?"

Qi Jiao looked at her: "Alright."

As long as she extended an invitation, Qi Jiao would put down all her work to accompany her for breakfast.

After eating breakfast, Chen Mian followed Qi Jiao to the flower shop.

Actually, to Qi Jiao, this was somewhat strange, and anyone else would find it strange too.

Because this was only the third day they'd known each other.

Chen Mian followed Qi Jiao around almost inseparably.

Inviting her to take walks, inviting her to dinner.

What was even stranger was that Qi Jiao agreed to everything.

These past few days, Qi Jiao couldn't forget that first glance when she saw Chen Mian—her heart racing, her eyes inexplicably moist, wanting to rush toward her, and those tearful eyes that kept appearing in her dreams that night.

Intuition told her that those eyes shouldn't be like that.

They should be cold, indifferent, disdainful.

Yet she could see endless affection beyond those emotions.

Even the fact that Chen Mian drove to her flower shop entrance early in the morning saying she'd take her to the morning market didn't seem strange to Qi Jiao.

Because this was exactly the kind of thing Chen Mian would do.

Chapter 193 - Part 2

Extra 15-2

Chen Mian's identity when she came here was that of an orphan, no longer having an Alpha's physique, just a very ordinary girl.

Her first twenty-some years were the kind of existence that would be submerged if placed in a crowd.

Chen Mian didn't want to do anything grand, and was even tired of being a painter or artist.

Having everything placed in display windows to be admired was a sad thing.

And Chen Mian hadn't yet decided what career to pursue, so she hovered around Qi Jiao.

Countless times, watching Qi Jiao working seriously from the side, she would silently space out.

Her thoughts drifting beyond the ninth heaven.

But even beyond the ninth heaven, it was still Qi Jiao.

This kind of day continued for a week.

In this week, Chen Mian had already thought of her career—she planned to become an art teacher at a nearby school.

Chen Mian used to really dislike the teaching profession, always feeling they were people seeking fame and reputation.

When in school, there was even a teacher who had talked about Qi Jiao in class, saying she was a delicate flower who never participated in school activities.

From that time on, Chen Mian didn't like the teaching profession.

Especially when Qi Jiao jumped from the school rooftop back then, those days at school became Chen Mian's nightmare countless times.

Chen Mian hated school for a period of time.

But recently she would occasionally see Qi Jiao sitting at the flower shop entrance in the evening, watching middle school students after school, watching them cross the pedestrian crossing, laughing and playing in groups of three or five.

Qi Jiao said: "Seeing middle school students makes one feel so energetic."

So Chen Mian decided to become a teacher.

Just that Chen Mian didn't expect that teachers at this school had to take exams—

So she learned a new term: bianzhi¹.

Chen Mian looked up a lot of information before understanding what this meant.

Qi Jiao asked in surprise: "You didn't know before?"

Chen Mian: "..."

Chen Mian silently studied educational knowledge.

Qi Jiao's flower shop business wasn't very good, but it wasn't bad either.

Every day people would come to buy flowers.

Sometimes it was affectionate couples, sometimes single girls returning home late from work, sometimes white-haired elderly people. Qi Jiao would recommend suitable flowers to all of them.

Chen Mian asked Qi Jiao: "Why did you want to open a flower shop?"

Qi Jiao thought for a moment and answered: "Flowers can bring people hope."

"I heard a saying before." Qi Jiao said: "The existence of flowers isn't to become scenery, but to make people's hearts peaceful."

Chen Mian: "..."

Chen Mian stood in front of the table, smiling as she asked: "Who said that?"

Qi Jiao shook her head: "I can't remember."

Qi Jiao also said: "I searched online and couldn't find where it came from either."

Chen Mian smiled softly, saying nothing.

Qi Jiao couldn't find the source because these were words Chen Mian had once said to her.

Unexpectedly, she still remembered.

After staying at the flower shop for a long time, Chen Mian gradually could also wrap beautiful flower arrangements.

But Qi Jiao said wrapping flowers wasn't suitable for her.

So Chen Mian asked: "Then what suits me?"

"How would I know?" Qi Jiao said, then paused and tentatively suggested: "Why don't you paint?"

So Chen Mian painted all the wrapped flowers in Qi Jiao's shop.

Almost no repeated color schemes each day.

Qi Jiao could always think of unique combinations.

And Chen Mian really liked painting on the street.

Moving a stool, setting up an easel, calmly starting to paint.

Chen Mian painted in oils, and occasionally people would come to watch.

Chen Mian's looks weren't outstanding, her features all quite ordinary, but combined together she had a unique temperament.

That kind of temperament unique to artists—"you can't stand me but you can't get rid of me either"—everyone thought she was aloof.

Qi Jiao would occasionally glance up inadvertently while wrapping flowers in the shop, and seeing Chen Mian's quiet silhouette would smile softly, that kind of unconsciously gentle smile.

One day a customer reminded her, and only then did she realize she'd been staring too intently.

But somehow, she just really liked Chen Mian.

The feeling that she was naturally meant to like her.

She also felt they must have known each other for a long time.

Even though aside from liking the same song "Lone Bird Syndrome," they liked many other things differently.

But Qi Jiao just felt it was right.

No one else could make her smile just by seeing them.

Only Chen Mian.

Chen Mian gradually became a beautiful sight at the entrance.

Naturally, this news couldn't be hidden from Qi Jiao's family.

During dinner that evening, her sister opened with: "Is someone pursuing you?"

Qi Jiao froze, her eyes darting around. Her brother immediately patted her head: "You're not the type to lie, tell the truth."

Qi Jiao put down her bowl with a red face, stammering: "There... there isn't."

Her sister and brother said in unison: "So it's true then."

Qi Jiao: "..."

Qi Jiao immediately fled.

While her parents gossiped: "Someone's pursuing Jiaojiao? How old? Handsome? What do they do for work?"

Her sister and brother exchanged glances, and finally her sister stated the harsh truth: "Don't know how old, it's a girl, looks okay I guess, not as pretty as Jiaojiao."

"A girl?" Her parents exclaimed in unison.

Finally her mother waved her hand, "Whatever, as long as Jiaojiao likes them, who cares if it's a boy or girl."

Meanwhile, Qi Jiao, who had fled back to her bedroom and was leaning against the door, suddenly felt her phone vibrate.

She opened it—it was a message from Chen Mian: [Want to watch the sunrise tomorrow morning?]

Footnotes:

¹ Bianzhi (编制) - A permanent position/establishment in the Chinese public sector system, particularly valued for job security and benefits in fields like education

Chapter 193 - Part 3

Extra 15-3

The place to watch the sunrise was in the suburbs, on a not-too-high mountain, driving out in the dark.

When Qi Jiao snuck out of her house, it was the first time she'd done this sort of thing.

Yet somehow, she felt a sense of familiarity.

As if many years ago, she had also done this kind of thing.

Anxious and afraid, yet full of anticipation.

In the distant sky, the pale white of dawn appeared, the sun slowly rising from behind the mountain.

Magnificent and romantic.

When Chen Mian went up the mountain, she brought a jacket, laying it down for Qi Jiao to sit on, her arms supporting herself against the rock behind.

Light spilled from ahead, amid the tranquil bird calls, amid the magnificent rays of dawn, Chen Mian's voice said very softly: "Qi Jiao, let's be together."

Qi Jiao looked over in shock, but unconsciously smiled.

Almost without hesitation, she answered: "Ao."

"What does 'ao' mean?" Chen Mian asked.

"It means yes." Qi Jiao turned her face back toward the rising sun.

Chen Mian said: "Don't you need to think about it more?"

Qi Jiao: "..."

"Then sing me a song." Qi Jiao said.

Qi Jiao thought Chen Mian would sing "Lone Bird Syndrome."

She'd heard Chen Mian hum that tune before.

But unexpectedly, after hesitating for a few seconds, Chen Mian's somewhat cool voice sang:

[Going around the school and flower shop

From wilderness to seaside

There's a kind of romantic love that is wasting time

Wandering to the prosperous world

Only to discover your silhouette

Is specially ordinary

...

Happiness made a circle]

Fortunately, it was just a circle.

Not a permanent farewell.

We are all just drops in the ocean, merely one among countless beings.

Yet there will still be people who discover the bright spots on ordinary you and me.

You must always remember: Even in places you cannot see, there will be people who steadfastly love you.